

“I’m bringing Kotak under one narrative, one strategy, one umbrella”

Kotak Mahindra Bank MD & CEO Ashok Vaswani on the road ahead for the bank

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Ashok Vaswani is a global banker who spent most of his career overseas at institutions like Citi Group and Barclays, among others. Around a year ago, he took charge of Kotak Mahindra Bank as MD & CEO. In an exclusive interview with *Business Today's Siddharth Zarabi*, the man at the helm of India's fourth-largest private bank talks about the country's banking sector, the challenges, and the road ahead for Kotak Mahindra Bank, among other things. Edited excerpts:

Q: How has the past year been?

A: I got back to India after 35 years, and I always joke that it took all those years of training for this job, but here I am. And this one year has been quite incredible. The India I left and the India I've come back [to are] obviously very, very, very different... But Kotak is an incredible story. It's a great brand. Kotak manufactures

every single financial services product there is. And getting those products and services to our customers is a unique opportunity. And I think Kotak has done exceptionally well in the past, and I think it's poised to do great things [in the times] to come.

Q: You took over at a time when India's banking space had gone through many changes. How would you describe it today?

A: I think Indian banking has come a long, long way. The Reserve Bank of India has done quite a remarkable job of opening up the banking industry, opening up financial services... When I left India in 1987, it was at an extremely nascent stage... [then] being able to get a car loan in like four to five days was considered a very, very big thing. But things have changed dramatically, and I think the RBI has guided this process along remarkably well and I am sure there will be further changes... The good news is that India has opened up on its own terms and will continue to do so.

Q: From an industry perspective, how would you describe the unsecured credit stress?

A: When Covid-19 hit, nobody knew how it would play out and when there is such a high degree of uncertainty, people pull back, and every other bank pulled back. And then the governments injected tremendous amounts of liquidity into the system and banks realised that this is not going to be such a problem from a lending perspective and waded back in aggressively. They went to the kind of customers who technically are the safest—the salaried kind—and aggressively gave them lending lines. There was bunch of salaried customers who got over-leveraged and there is a certain